

Indigenous resurgence in Canada is a broad intellectual, cultural, political, and social movement that emphasizes the revitalization of Indigenous nations through the renewal of Indigenous laws, languages, governance, relationships to land, and cultural practices. While related to Indigenous rights movements, resurgence places particular emphasis on Indigenous decolonization and self-determination arising from Indigenous traditions and responsibilities rather than recognition or accommodation by the Canadian state.

Resurgence is a form of regenerative nation-building and reconnection with all their relations, kin-centric relationships among BIPOC peoples and with the natural world. Rather than focusing exclusively on negotiations with governments or litigation, proponents emphasize rebuilding Indigenous societies from within by restoring traditional governance systems, strengthening languages, practicing Indigenous legal traditions, protecting lands and waters, and transmitting cultural knowledge between generations.

History

Indigenous resurgence emerges from the long-standing Indigenous response to colonialism. It was formalized in the early 2000s (especially by Alfred and Corntassel), and broadened in the 2010s through scholars like Simpson into a collection of frameworks emphasizing everyday, land-based, and relational forms of Indigenous nationhood renewal.

Theoretical framework

Leanne Betasamosake Simpson (2016) explains that the Indigenous resurgence movements were not created to change the current settler colonial system, rather resurgent movements are aiming for a different approach. She states that the way forward is to create new, alternative worlds with "profoundly different ways of thinking, organizing, and being because the Indigenous processes that give birth to our collective resurgence are fundamentally non-hierarchical, nonexploitative, nonextractivist, and nonauthoritarian." (pp. 22–23).

Theorists of Indigenous resurgence define colonialism as the dispossession and the erasure of people, bodies, histories, knowledges, ceremonies, sense of place, and of the land. These are replaced with compartmentalized state-imposed definitions of indigeneity and of the land which value individualism and extractive capitalism.

Indigenous resurgence is defined as an individual's personal change through daily acts of resistance against the constructs and the limitations set by the settler colonialist state; to resist being what is expected and to live, study, work, and act within the Indigenous ways of being. This personal act transforms into community acts of revitalization that take into account the collective needs of the community and of the natural world, based on each community's own beliefs and traditional knowledges.

The acts of resurgence reclaim the Indigenous storyline, a counter-narrative, drawing away from hurt and grief, toward a future of hope. Glen Coulthard states that Indigenous resurgence is a movement of nation building and decolonizing through the framework of grounded normativity. This framework is defined as place-based solidarity employing Indigenous Knowledges. Its practices and procedures are based on reciprocal kin-centric relations among people and with the natural world. Grounded Normativity does not engage with the current systems of white supremacy, heteropatriarchy, and capitalism.

The practice of Indigenous resurgence creates space for new ways of community development, engagement, and governance. Through mutual support and co-resistance by like-minded individuals and BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, People of Colour) communities, Indigenous resurgence can affect change in justice, politics, education, organization, mobilization, and governance. The revitalization and regeneration of Indigenous languages, cultural practices, land management, relationship building, spiritual connection, and community solidarity are some of the benefits that the theorists of Indigenous resurgence expect to gain.

Application

As the lands and customs of Indigenous peoples vary, the actions of each movement may represent the peoples in a variety of ways. Taiaiake Alfred and Jeff Corntassel (2005) elaborate that, "There is no concise neat model of resurgence in this way of approaching decolonization and the regeneration of our peoples." (pp. 612) There cannot be a "how-to" manual that can be replicated, each individual and each community should define their own terms based on their real needs and their own knowledges, using measures and practices to protect and to reconnect individuals and communities with the natural world.

The following actions are examples of Indigenous resurgence movements occurring in Canada. The list is not, and may never be, exhaustive.

Arts

Indigenous musical group, The Halluci Nation (formerly known as "A Tribe Called Red"), is described as "adapting the music and culture of the contemporary pow wow, A Tribe Called Red exemplifies the remixing of tradition at the heart of the current Indigenous resurgence." (pp. 29–30)

Food sovereignty

The Nuu-chah-nulth Tribal Council (NTC) in British Columbia sustainably and autonomously governs the use of the Nation's traditional foods, including foods derived from their marine space. The Nation honours the foods collected through yearly ceremonial songs and prayers. The food management policies allow for the revitalization of their traditional practices, to have food sovereignty, and to create healthier communities.

The Batchewana First Nation (BFN) in Ontario is exercising self-determination and practicing food sovereignty through the traditional and sustainable management of small-scale fisheries situated in Lake Superior. This resurgence movement provides the opportunity for the Nation

to revitalize traditional ecological practices and have jurisdiction over the waters they harvest from.

The Michi Saagiig Nation located in Ontario have reclaimed their land and their waters. Through their traditional knowledges and practices, the Nation self-determines their rights to manage hunting, fishing, and the cultivation of wild rice on their lands.

Health

Indigenous-led health centres located within the city of Prince George, British Columbia, provide a sense of community and safety to its members. The focus on relationship building provides the Indigenous community the safe space to participate in activities created for their wellbeing and to access health services accommodated for their needs.

Political

Idle No More is a movement of resistance and resurgence begun by Indigenous Peoples belonging to the lands located in Canada. The movement began in 2012 to oppose Prime Minister Harper's government changes, especially to Bill C-45 which contained changes to the Indian Act and to environmental protection. There were several successful acts of resistance and resurgence spanning the whole country. The movement was largely successful due to mass communication across social media outlets.

Online resurgence practices

During the COVID-19 pandemic, Indigenous people created an account on Instagram to allow the safe space for Indigenous people to share their everyday resurgence activities. The aim was to engage and nurture community relations in a revolutionary way through social media, and to promote wellness during the time of social distancing. The account is "Everyday Indigenous Resurgence."

Storytelling

The author, Richard Wagamese, wrote his novel, *Indian Horse*, as a narrative of a Residential School healing journey. The protagonist, Saul, reconnects with the land and develops the capacity to share oral stories on this journey. Through the relationship building with his ancestors and the land, he finds identity and community. The novel itself is a form of storytelling as healing and resurgence.

Related reading

Indigenous authors and related literature

Taiaiake Alfred, Kanienkehaka Nation from Kahnawake, Quebec.

Indigenous Pathways of Action and Freedom, Peterborough, ON, Broadview Press, 2005.

Peace, Power and Righteousness: An Indigenous Manifesto (Toronto: Oxford University Press Canada, 1999).

Heeding the Voices of Our Ancestors: Kahnawake Mohawk Politics and the Rise of Native Nationalism, Oxford, Oxford University Press

"Deconstructing the British Columbia Treaty Process", *Balayi: Culture, Law and Colonialism*, 3 (2001), p. 49.

Angele Alook, Bigstone Cree Nation, Treaty 8, Alberta, and Crystal Lameman, Beaver Lake Cree Nation, Alberta.

Kim Anderson, Cree/Metis with Red River, Manitoba roots.

A Recognition of Being: Reconstructing Native Womanhood, Toronto, Sumach Press, 2000.

Jeff Corntassel, Cherokee Nation.

"'Deadliest Enemies' or Partners in the 'Utmost Good Faith': Conflict Resolution Strategies for Indian Nation / State Disputes in an Era of Forced Federalism", *Ayaangwaamizin: International Journal of Indigenous Philosophy*, 3 (Summer 2003) pp. 141–67.

Jeff Corntassel and RC Witmer, *Forced Federalism: Contemporary Challenges to Indigenous Nationhood*, Norman, University of Oklahoma Press, 2008.

"Who is Indigenous? 'Peoplehood' and Ethnonationalist Approaches to Rearticulating Indigenous Identity", *Nationalism & Ethnic Politics*, 9 (2003), pp. 75–100.

Glen Coulthard, Dene First Nation from Yellowknife, Northwest Territories.

Red Skin, White Masks: Rejecting the Colonial Politics of Recognition (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2014), 60.

Lee Maracle, Stó:lō Nation from North Vancouver, British Columbia.

I Am Woman: A Native Perspective on Sociology and Feminism (Vancouver: Press Gang Publishers, 1996).

Leanne Betasamosake Simpson, Mississauga Nishnaabeg Nation from Alderville First Nation.

Dancing on Our Turtle's Back: Stories of Nishnaabeg Re-Creation, Resurgence and a New Emergence (Winnipeg: Arbeiter Ring, 2011).

Non-Indigenous authors

Frantz Fanon, *The Wretched of the Earth*, New York, Grove Press, 1963.

Bernard Nietschmann, "The Fourth World: Nations Versus States", in George J. Demko and William B. Wood (eds), *Reordering the World: Geopolitical Perspectives on the 21st Century*, Philadelphia, Westview Press, 1995, pp. 228.

See also

Land Back

== References ==